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1. Overview

1.1. Theses

1.1.1. Play as the method of aesthetic inquiry

The aesthetic attitude is the manner by which we take on new standpoints and thus bring our standpoints into question. The manner by which one explores the possibility space opened up by the aesthetic attitude is play. Thus, play is a powerful and radical tool for philosophical and aesthetic exploration.

1.1.2. Thinking like a designer: Creating the aesthetic artifact

The goal when creating philosophy and art is not to think like a player, but to think like a *designer*. The goal of reading philosophy or experiencing art is to have your perspective changed. But when creating the experience, you have to consider your audience's perspective and the best ways to change them. The very work of aesthetic design is to shake up the reader's worldview, to loosen them up a little bit. Your goal is to create the rules of play in which the reader immerses themselves. But the rules do not only encompass rules in the traditional sense of limitations, but also bare facts: the composition of brush strokes on a canvas, the delicate movement of a concerto, the precise controls of a platformer game. These are the restrictions, or in Noë's term, *resistances*, through which a free space is opened up for play. Recall our definition of play as free movement within a restricted plane. Without the restrictions, there is no play. (Hans agrees on this point.)

1.1.3. Play as the space-between: Conceptualization

Play marks the space in which conceptualization takes place; it is the ground upon which the rules are made, upon which differentiation occurs. It is the body without organs, it is the space of *différance*. It is the space in Saussurean semiotics in which conceptualization opens up, *between words* so to speak; the space of meaning-making in the distinction between words, their meaning only occurring through the entire net of symbolic representation (Quine's network of beliefs). Derrida considers it both "temporizing" and "spacing" (Derrida 2026). Play is the free movement of the psyche within the rigid conceptualization of the symbolic order. The unconscious moves freely and finds resistances in the structure of symbols. The aesthetic revs up the engines, in Kant's sense, and gets the play moving. It confronts us with new ideas and ways of symbolizing, it shakes up the symbolic order, pushing at its boundaries until something comes loose and we re-conceptualize.

1.2. Some meta-level concerns

I do not want this to be a totalizing account of epistemology. It is, like all good philosophies, about a *particular* manner of engaging with the world. It is itself a playful stance, an aesthetic, which can account for other aesthetics. Hans' account fails to avoid totalization despite attempts.

1.3. Key Concepts

1.3.1. Play

Play has several meanings. The one we focus on is transformative play, the play of the metagame – play which modifies the very rules of play. This sort of play is entangled, in Noë's sense of the term. In addition to transformative play, there is mechanical play (play broadly construed to include e.g. physical notions of play), being-playful (play construed as a willingness to mold or shift one's perspective, to *break* the rules or to bend them), play as rule-following (e.g. striving play, wherein one takes on the temporary goals of a game so as to accomplish some meta-level goal).

Play as rule-following, our typical playful activity, is an interesting case because it is simultaneously mechanical and meta-level. Our concerns are only temporarily vested in the act of the game – our larger goals live at a higher level. Our goals in playing the game change the way in which the game is played. For example if we are teaching a young person to play a game, we want to make sure they maintain an interest by going easy on them, allowing them to win from time to time. But if we are playing the game competitively, our brains kick into high gear: what's wrapped up in the game is far more than an education, but pride and identity, perhaps even prize money, a championship, one's livelihood. So-called serious games also take on a more responsible role in our lives, for example teaching nurses to cope with their jobs, or boot camp simulations training soldiers for the battlefield. The history of games as a medium is tied up with the development of war games in general, perhaps the most serious games of them all.

How to consider ludic activity, i.e., messing around? Teasing, tussling, tossing a ball around. As a kind of manipulative play, wherein the rules and boundaries of our external world, be they social or physical, are tested?

– Much of my analysis of play has to do with the *function* of play more than the phenomenology of it. There is not much discussion here of joy or desire. That feels a bit out of scope – I do not consider e.g. the evolutionary psychology of play or its place in culture in large, but rather focus on its role in our relationship to the Real (the unconscious, the noumenal, etc.), i.e. its ontological and epistemological significance.

1.3.1.1. Taxonomy

Play happens when free movement occurs within a rigid structure. Let's break that down. In what domains can play occur? What sort of structures give rise to play? What is 'free movement?'

These terms are overly broad. But perhaps their breadth is an asset. Free movement evokes the graceful swoops of a flycatcher, the stochastic movement of thermodynamic particles, and the fancy of an active imagination in equal measure. But these are vastly distinct domains: animal behavior, the movement of atoms, and theoretical postulation. In each case this behavior is restricted by bounds: the bird must fight against gravity and wind; the particles must respect the forces acting upon and against them; and the mind is bound by the rules of logic and conceptual framework in which it is situated. Without the wind and the pull of the earth there is no flight;

without a wall to bounce against there is no heat pressure; without a constitutive framework there is no room for theorization, no concepts to bounce back against or deductive rules to follow. So we have established that **free movement cannot occur without restriction**. The phrase ‘free movement within a rigid structure’ is in fact redundant: there is no free movement without a rigid structure. But can we show the reverse? Does a rigid structure presuppose the possibility of free movement?

This one is more difficult. It seems quite clear that a universe solely consisting of static matter is possible, if not in fact more likely. But in this case, the *static* nature gives away the game: if there is nothing for it to bound, is it a structure at all? Even the empty set provides a base structure: the *possibility* to be filled. A monistic universe, consisting of only a single fact, perhaps of *nothing at all*, is still structured by the rules of logical necessity, still conceptually bound by its negation. So it is the structure of our discourse that is limiting us. To solve this we need to take a step back and look at the structure which comprises our conceptual schemata.

Here I take inspiration from Zen Buddhist accounts of the structure of consciousness. From whence do our conceptions arise in the first place? Nishida calls this the place of absolute nothingness (*basho no zettai mu*). De Sassure and Derrida might consider it the space in which the differential between concepts occurs, the background on which *différance* is made manifest. For Heidegger it is similar to *das Nichts* or *der Lichtung*, the formless nothingness from which all Being springs forth.

Each of these accounts point toward a meta-level consciousness, something that is beyond the direct layer of perception. I take Albahari’s term *witness consciousness* to describe this higher-level perception.

1. Structural rigidity

- Mechanical play vs transformative play – mechanical play occurs *within* the structure, is rule-bound; transformative play *changes* the structure, occurs at a meta level

2. Domain

- physical, mechanical, rule-bound
 - physical laws, rule-bound play, *deterministically automatable*, “games” in the “game theory” sense.
 - This sense of play is not necessarily agentic. Agents definitely play like this, but not *only* agents exhibit this sort of behavior.
 - Is this a credible notion of “play?” Is this not just ‘stochastic behavior?’ – There seems to be a sort of *strategic incentive* to reach an optimistic state. Physical phenomena certainly achieve this. Though it stretches the notion of play far beyond traditional credibility.
- biological, chemical, transformative
 - agentic, theoretic, onto-epistemological -> a kind of transformative play

3. Levels

- rule-bound play
- metagaming
- design

1.3.2. Trauma

As the unwilling counter to play. As the rigid structure which *prevents* the free movement. When the resistances become too much to bear. When one is trapped within one's rigid ruleset and unable to escape it, despite the need to do so. When symbolization cannot capture the real. (Lacan, Lecture XI)

A case study: An old woman in Kyiv grieves as her grandson is carried from the rubble of their bombed apartment building. How is she to cope? Her symbolic order has been utterly destroyed: the structures which upheld her life (presumably, revolving largely around her grandson) have been ripped from her. The encounter with the real cannot fit within the rules she has built for her life. Now, regardless of her will, she *must* reconstitute her symbolic order. She has no choice. It is either resymbolize, or become delusional.

The process of healing for her will consist in finding the joy in the play within her new symbolic order. To willingly accept the new order and participate in the rule-bound structure which it offers. The resistances of the symbolic order provide rigidity. They are adaptive. But they can be deceiving. It behooves us to keep our strictures in mind, and to maintain a willingness to play within their boundaries, to push up against them and see where they give. Much like learning carpentry, you must first strip a few screws before you know when to stop.

1.3.3. Ecstasy

- Being outside of oneself
- Key argument: This is the default. Self-awareness is not the default point of view.

Self-awareness occurs precisely at the moment when our perceptual rules break down, when our symbolizing structures need to be updated.

We are by default 'lost in the sauce' of our symbolic structures. We are too busy playing the game to think existentially, ontologically. We are alerted to the ontic when we have an encounter with the aesthetic, that is, with beauty; or when we are confronted with the traumatic.

1.3.4. Entanglement

Hans talks about grafts on fields of production. This is basically the same thing as the entanglement. Our fields of production came from random sources and are based on a tradition, and it is the acknowledgement of the tradition which makes the new grafts possible. It is both transcendent and immanent, meta and base level, in a circle, or better, a Möbius strip. Cf the hermeneutic circle.

Production is the production of *anything*, production generally construed. Production of goods, of services, of action in general. Play then as the way production happens. Cf Hans ch 2, Production. Play is how production happens, on 'fields of play' (or aesthetic fields), which consist of a series of grafts stratified into a culture or tradition. Acknowledgement of the tradition lends itself to a modification of the rules (metagaming) which produces new grafts and potentially opens us up to new fields of play.

1.3.5. Desire

Desiring-production at the heart of Hans' conception of play. Two kinds of production: ecstatic production and violent production. Both are intertwined. This is my conception of play and trauma; willing play and unwilling play; willing reorientation and unwilling reorientation; it is the difference between exhilaration and chaos.

1.3.6. The Aesthetic

The aesthetic: ways of *seeing*; they are 'fields of play' or sets of rules to follow, they are ontologies and epistemologies which shape our worldviews. This is *felt* as well as it is theorized. It is *experienced, lived* in the full sense of the term. It is a manner of our Being-in-the-world, the fundamental root of our existential conditions. But what early Heidegger misunderstood is that there are many of them, and that we are always switching between them; that the fields of play are intermeshed, and the boundaries can blur. (How does this square with the rule-bound conception? Ethics as aesthetics, or the rules by which an aesthetic is bound? – but that's a different essay.)

1.3.7. Design and Metagaming

Design is the art of crafting experiences. Metagaming is the practice of grafting. Both tie into the aesthetic, into fields of play: they create new rules, bring fields together or drive them apart. Design is the art of changing an individual's understanding, construed as a way of relating to the world (one's Being). Metagaming is the process by which design happens. The philosopher's goal, as the artist's, is to be a designer in this sense: to create ways of seeing, to bring new ways of Being into the world; to graft together fields of play and create new kinds of production, new desires. The task of the artist is to design an experience; the task of the philosopher is to train the designer. (Is that the right phrasing?)

1.4. Aspirational Bibliography

On ekstasis in the literary tradition on aesthetics:

Suggested reading path

1. Longinus, On the Sublime (Fyfe/Russell trans.)
2.  Kant, Critique of Judgment, Analytic of the Sublime
3.  Nietzsche, The Birth of Tragedy
4. Bataille, Inner Experience
5. Gadamer, Truth and Method, Part I
6. Weiskel, The Romantic Sublime; Hertz, The End of the Line
7. Scarry, On Beauty and Being Just; Felski, Uses of Literature

On a prior thesis, and citations to Nguyen, Noë, and others <https://pi.dev/session/#46547b79f9cd241965ab2c533704c10d>

- The Play of the World – Hans (Hans 1981)

- Meta-gaming - Boluck & LeMieux (Boluk and LeMieux 2017)
- Strange Tools - Noë (Noë 2015)
- ✓ The Entanglement - Noë (Noë 2023)
- ✓ What Is Philosophy? - D&G (Deleuze et al. 2014)
- The Score - Nguyen (Nguyen 2026)
- ✓ Games: Agency as Art - Nguyen (Nguyen 2025)
- The Routledge Guide to the Philosophy of Games - Nguyen et al
- Network Aesthetics - Jagoda
- ✓ Experimental Games - Jagoda (Jagoda 2020)
- ✓ Rules of Play - Boluck & LeMieux (Salen Tekinbaş and Zimmerman 2004)
- Crisis in European Sciences - Husserl (Husserl et al. 1984)
- Philosophical Investigations - Wittgenstein (Wittgenstein et al. 2010)
- ✓ Critique of Judgement - Kant (Kant et al. 2007)
- ✓ Birth of Tragedy - Nietzsche
- Inner Experience - Bataille
- Lacan lecture XI (6-9, 13-16) - primer (Lacan and Miller 1998)
 - Possibly XX ch 6. Saint Teresa and feminine jouissance
 - Possibly VII 18-21 on beauty
- Homo Ludens - Huizinga (Huizinga 2014)

1.5. TO EXPLORE

1.5.1. Generalization and stereotypes

Play and the aesthetic attitude help us *generalize* while avoiding *overgeneralizing*. They help us *cope* with everyday life. They provide us flexibility when our established rules are shown to be wrong. Play is at the heart of scientific revolution. Play is at the heart of discovery. See here: How we meet the future - Tom Ralston, ed. Nigel Warburton

1.5.2. Play and trauma

Play and trauma as lapses into the Real. D&G's progression of society as through breaks and lapses in the signifying culture through either schizophrenic play or paranoiac rupture (trauma). Trauma *forces* us into the aesthetic attitude, or is caused by our inability to enter it. Play is a wilful engagement with it.

1.6. Rough outline

1. Two takes on the aesthetic attitude - Nguyen and Noë.
 1. How do each of our philosophers spell out their attitudes?
 1. Nguyen as a limited conception of aesthetics as striving play toward a particular goal. His usage is limited to gameplay and e.g. corporate life. What Husserl would term vocational. Nguyen's conception is restricted to rule-following attitudes.

2. Noë brings the aesthetic attitude to a global scale. If Nguyen describes gaming, Noë describes metagaming. His claim (a provocative one) is that the aesthetic attitude is essential to our Being and is what underscores the fact that we are problems to ourselves. Our meta-level contemplation is essential. But the superstructure modifies the base in what he terms the entanglement. We are wrapped up in habits and traditions of which we are aware and which we are free to break with and thus to modify. Our particular habits are defined by style, a particular way of going about our activities. Styles change over time against a background of tradition through a process of meta-level understanding and base-level modification.
 3. Ironically, in *Strange Tools*, Noë argues that sports cannot be games. Nguyen, in *Games: Agency as Art*, decries this and shows how games can indeed be art. The idea is that Noë's conception of what baseball players are doing is limited. Nguyen introduces the idea of striving play, that is, playing for the sake of the game, as a kind of uptake of the aesthetic attitude. It is this attitude that turns gameplay into a kind of artistic activity. I will argue that gameplay is in fact one of the most important aesthetic activities. The various characteristics of gameplay provide a clear articulation of what it means to take up the aesthetic attitude and provides a wealth of examples of its use. In particular, the practices of gaming and metagaming will prove fruitful for our analysis as a parallel between Noë's base and meta-level activities. I will show that gaming and metagaming provide all the necessary features of the entanglement and provide a framework and rich literature for understanding the aesthetic attitude.
2. What are the tasks of the aesthetic attitude? (Positive and negative)
2. Varieties of ekstasis
 1. What is ecstasy and why does it matter?
 1. Ecstasy (ekstasis) is literally defined as being away from oneself. This is precisely the vocational bracketing that Husserl describes. Interestingly, it has connotations of pleasure. This may relate to the game-playing attitude which underlies it.
 2. Sex and psychoanalysis - drive (libido)
 1. Focus, flow-state, sexual desire and the libido. Draw on Lacan here, possibly D&G's desiring machines. Social and individual investment are not the same: they are entangled. D&G go to far in equating the two.
 3. Contemplation - philosophy and the arts
 1. This is Noë's whole shit. Draw heavily from *The Entanglement* and *Strange Tools*.
 4. Code-switching and speech
 1. Code-switching is when you take on the aesthetic attitude of one group for a time, then switch to another. This shows itself in speech, for example Black interpersonal speech as opposed to formal interracial speech (especially towards White folks). Similarly, code-switching from an autistic perspective to an allistic perspective (masking), or code-switching from one gender expression to another (gender fluidity) (e.g. literally genderfluid people, also drag). These exhibit a *multitude* of aesthetic attitudes and demonstrate the flexibility that we have in choosing our attitude. The fluidity by which

one can code-switch is a kind of skill. And, as in Noë's conception, once you know how to speak in one dialect you never really un-learn it. (Wittgenstein's know-how vs know-that – you never un-learn how to ride a bike.)

2. Potential citations: Autism, sexuality, and BDSM. Something on code-switching in Black speech. Code-switching in gender identity (Noë's point on Butler's conception of gender as performance: it is an aesthetic attitude toward our sexed beings).
5. Scientific pursuit
 1. Scientific pursuit is a particular attitude defined by mathematical rigor and a material-reductionist approach to studying the natural world. Noë, toward the end of *The Entanglement*.
 2. Counter D&G here: science as non-fundamental compared to the aesthetic attitude: it is an *application* of the aesthetic attitude and not a fundamental orientation. Our fundamental orientation, insofar as we have one, is to be flexible.
3. Play and the magic circle: the shared characteristic of all ekstasis
 1. The magic circle is defined as the 'realm of play;' to use Husserl's terms it is the vocational attitude applied to a particular task. What makes a task a game rather than work is something to do with the motivations and benefits of pursuing that task. In any case the task pursued is part of the aesthetic attitude.
 2. Flirtation, consensual sex, speech and language games, code switching, and gameplay all exhibit the aesthetic attitude - a way of changing our Being-in-the-world, and as such a way of *examining* our Being. Contemplation is the meta-level act of understanding our own understandings and considering what could happen if those understandings changed. This cannot happen without play.
 3. Play has several senses. In the first sense I intend play as it is typical understood in gameplay. Gameplay is a manner of rule-following. It is what happens when we take up the aesthetic attitude, the vocational attitude as it were. Another sense of the world 'play,' and the one I want to focus on here, can be defined as a loose experimentation where the boundaries of one's subject and the rules of the game are up for interpretation. This can be considered a form of meta-gaming.
 1. In *Rules of Play*, Salem and Zimmerman propose three definitions. From lowest to highest abstraction, these are game play, ludic activity, and "being playful" or the "spirit of play." (p303). In general, play is defined as "free movement within a more rigid structure" (304).
 2. 👉 There are many kinds of play, but the one I want to focus on is **transformative play**. This "occurs when the free movement of play alters the more rigid structure in which it takes shape." (311). This is clearly parallel to Noë's concept of the entanglement. Not all play has this entangled characteristic. It is transformative play in particular which is at the heart of entanglement and the aesthetic attitude.¹

¹They cite James S. Hans: "The role of play is not to work comfortably within its own structures but rather constantly to develop its structures through play." This is exactly what I'm trying to articulate! *The Play of the World*, 1981, p. 5

4. Metagaming and code-switching: the fluidity of the aesthetic attitude. DID as a disordered form of its extremity. Antisocial personality disorder and some expressions of autism as playing the game incorrectly, either as cheater, spoilsport, or non-participant.
 - On thinking like a designer.
5. Normalcy is just another game. The ‘natural attitude’ that Husserl describes is not so much a background predisposition as it is a learned habitus that we use in certain scenarios, e.g. at home, at work, at the doctor’s office. Each of these locations has their own game to play and their own attitude to take up. There is no underlying basic habitus, only a ‘default’ which could well be anything. (Perhaps Nguyen has something to say here in *The Score*)
6. TO EXPLORE: **The hermeneutic circle and the magic circle - what’s the difference?**
 - Okay clearly the magic circle more closely relates to Hans’ ‘fields of play’ than the hermeneutic circle, but both are significant. The hermeneutic circle is closer to the entanglement but specifically for language. cf Hans p105

1.7. Outline take 2

1. Defining play
 1. Hans, Nguyen, and Salem and Zimmerman on definitions of play.
 - See ch1 defining play
 2. The ontoepistemological significance of play
 - See “defining play.typ”
 3. A note on rules and games
2. Thinking like a designer

1.8. Some thoughts on an audience

Who is this essay for? I mean, ideally, it’s for me. Maybe it’s for people who don’t take play seriously. Maybe it’s for the old men at my college awards ceremony who were surprised when they asked, “So what’s next?” and I replied, “Video games.” Maybe it’s for Ari, to show her that I am an academic. That one’s unlikely. Maybe it’s for graduate admissions. Though again this is too complex for a single essay – maybe an excerpt would suffice. Maybe it’s for a general audience – a published book, along the lines of what Žižek and Noë are doing. Maybe it’s directed toward Jagoda and his project. Maybe it’s a thesis, to define what my project is in the first place.

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2. Quotes

2.1. *The Entanglement*

2.1.1. The aesthetic

The aesthetic names the ever-ongoing process of bringing what there is into an always fragile focus; it is the movement, always subject to second-guessing, from not seeing to seeing, or from seeing to seeing differently. The aesthetic is the fragile, productive (but

also entangled) enacting of our consciousness itself. [...] We organize ourselves [...] by representing ourselves by ourselves. This representing is fragile: it never evades the rivalry, the availability of the aspect shift, or the second guess. It is productive: it isn't the work of self-making and also world-making, for we change ourselves and change what is there for us in the very act. And it is entangled, for we do all this always against the background of the situations in which we find ourselves including, as it does, everything that has come before, including all our past self-representations.

— (Noë 2023, p222-223)

2.2. *The Play of the World*

2.2.1. Hans on transformative play

Hans defines play as follows:

1. "The essence of play is its capacity to saturate virtually every aspect of our lives, though not continuously." (Hans 1981, p2)
2. "The willingness to forego one's own territory, to be willing to pass beyond what one knows one is capable of, is the fundamental feature of play." (Hans 1981, p13)
3. "Still, whereas play is free in the sense that there is no Being in which to ground it, it is also bound in two crucial senses: first the beginning of play is always necessarily connected to a foreproject, to a series of prejudgments that are at issue in the activity of play itself, that give an orientation for the play; and second, the result of play is a structure, a framework or order that has been confirmed by the play itself." (Hans 1981, p10)

2.2.2. Hans on desire (ch3)

The problem is how to reconcile production of desire – or ecstatic desire – and consumption of desire – or violent desire. Structurally, they are reconciled by the fact that both lead to undifferentiation, to the loss of difference which in turn generates a new series of differences, and by the fact that both are also imitative processes. In the play of production, imitation is central, but it is the imitation of play itself that is the goal, and implicit in that desire to imitate play is also a willing suspension of difference. [...] One need not worry about imitation leading to identity, for identity itself is not possible. One's imitation is always a graft, so it is always an imitation with a difference[. ...] It is the connection of difference that provides the play, the production, and the graft, and it is this connection, openly conceded, that provides the difference between the two models we have been looking at.

— (Hans 1981, p81)

Very much in the realm of Deleuze and Guattari, Derrida, Gadamer, Nietzsche, Lacan (via D&G). This is chapter 3 of Hans. Key ideas: play as the production of the Real (cf ch2) non-self, desiring-production, mimesis, unification of ecstasy and violence, critique of D&G, critical-theoretical applications

- Passive vs active syntheses (p54, p56), play and the production of the Real (p54ff)
- The copper fitting metaphor (p58) – pragmatism
- Entanglement and fields of play (p59-60)
- Girard and the violence of mimesis; underscores violent desire (p64ff)
- Reconciliation of violence and ecstasis (p66) “Indeed as a qualitative experience they are identical; only the interpretation and the consequences differ.” “When a Sade or a Bataille comes along, we either reject their work as beastly or nod and agree that there is something there and promptly forget about it.” (p67)
- Ties to *The Birth of Tragedy*, Apollonian, Dionysian, and Socratic conceptions (p67-72)
- Lack vs fullness as valid kinds of desire: (p72-74)
- Critical-theoretical analysis (p74-79), drifts into metaphysics (p79) (spacing/temporizing); on identity (personal identity, though maybe he also intends mathematical identity) (p80-81)
- Conclusion and summary (p81-84)

2.3. Peter Cole - On Givenness

What if givenness *isn't* enough —
 and the wind's slithering along my arm
 is really a subtle summery alarm
 trying to tell me something else,
 and much rougher?

That worth, for instance,
 depends on a violence of difference
 and therefore
 inevitably lies at a certain distance
 from the stuff of life and us?
 That even givenness has to be taken
 hold of,
 at least by a kind of frame—
 if not a reaching for steeper comparison?
 And here it is,
 as though it were kissing
 the thinnest of skins on my arm, or name.

— (Cole 2017)

2.4. Kinds of Play (Rules of Play)

1. **Game Play:** the formalized, focused interaction that occurs when players follow the rules of a game in order to play it.

2. **Ludic activities:** non-game behaviors in which participants are “playing,” such as two tussling animals or a group of children tossing a ball in a circle. Game play is a subset of ludic activities.
3. **Being playful:** the state of being in a playful state of mind, such as when a spirit of play is injected into some other action. This category includes both game play and ludic activities.

— (Salen Tekinbaş and Zimmerman 2004, p?)

2.4.1. Mechanical play

Play, in general, is “Free movement within a more rigid structure” (Salen Tekinbaş and Zimmerman 2004, p304). I consider this ‘mechanical play.’ Broad definition applicable to all kinds of play. “Mechanical” in that it invokes the sense of e.g. the play of gears in a machine. I conceive this as the consequence of randomness of chaotic behavior in physical phenomena, so I also dub it ‘physical play.’

2.4.2. Transformative play

“Transformative play is a special case of play that occurs when the free movement of play alters the more rigid structure in which it takes shape. The play doesn’t just occupy and oppose the interstices of the system, but actually transforms the space as a whole.” (Salen Tekinbaş and Zimmerman 2004, p305) Play as mimesis-with-difference. I call this ‘biological play’ because it is reminiscent of the process of evolution. Supervenes on mechanical play, but is not the same thing. Requires a prerequisite structure and ability to copy. These can be explained e.g. in the origins of life as chemical processes; the copying and mutation of genes. (Interesting recent studies show that life had to evolve at least twice – two pairs of genomes had to come together to form proteins, chaotically tangled entities, which are the gears of life, providing it its play.)

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3. Defining play

3.1. Background

Hans defines play as follows:

1. “The essence of play is its capacity to saturate virtually every aspect of our lives, though not continuously.” (Hans 1981, p2)
2. “The willingness to forego one’s own territory, to be willing to pass beyond what one knows one is capable of, is the fundamental feature of play.” (Hans 1981, p13)
3. “Still, whereas play is free in the sense that there is no Being in which to ground it, it is also bound in two crucial senses: first the beginning of play is always necessarily connected to a foreproject, to a series of prejudgments that are at issue in the activity of play itself, that give

an orientation for the play; and second, the result of play is a structure, a framework or order that has been confirmed by the play itself.” (Hans 1981, p10)

He is quite clearly talking about *transformative play* as defined by (Salen Tekinbaş and Zimmerman 2004, p305). “Transformative play is a special case of play that occurs when the free movement of play alters the more rigid structure in which it takes shape. The play [...] transforms the space as a whole.” In fact, they quote Hans here: “The role of play is not to work comfortably within its own structures but rather constantly to develop its structures through play.” (Hans 1981, p5)

Also though, play in this sense is entangled, as in meta-gaming: transformative play is bound by rules but at the same time changes them.

I would say that transformative play *must first be bound by rules*, what Hans would call the ‘foreproject.’ If there are no rules there is nothing to play against. It is only with restriction that we can play at all. See def. of play in *Rules of Play* as “free movement within a more rigid structure” (Salen Tekinbaş and Zimmerman 2004, p304). Hans talks about play in both the his coined transformative sense, but also in the broader sense as defined by Salen and Zimmerman. When Hans shifts from an agential structure (focusing on activity, especially human activity) to discuss the playful structure of nature he describes play as “limited and not clearly definable – some of our ‘laws’ of physics, for example, point to the present limits of natural play – but within those limits natural play is capable of an infinite number of new grafts and connections.” (Hans 1981, p16-17)²

I read Hans as having several admixed conceptions of play. The first is agential, having to do with action, the second is onto-epistemological, having to do with our understanding of the world, and the third is mechanical (what Hans terms “natural”), having to do with the free play of entities within a structure. I will call the first *agentic play*, the second *theoretic play*, and the third *mechanical play*. Agentic play, claims Hans, is the basic attitude of our interaction with the world. This feeds into our theoretic play, which has to do with our conceptual understanding and modelling of the world. The reason this all works out so well is that the physical world is itself in a state of “natural play,” exploring the freedom within the natural laws. In the end, all play is supposed to be based on natural play, or play in the broadest sense. Mechanical play is the sort of play that occurs between the fittings of a copper pipe, or the turn of a screwdriver. Mechanical play, and thus play most broadly, is free movement within the constraints of set of rules.

Let’s take a second here to clarify the notion of mechanical play in its relation to nature. First off, when I speak of the laws of physics, I should not be construed to be speaking about physical phenomena which are essential, structuring aspects of the universe, but rather statistical propositions which require certain magnitudes of scale. Certain macro-level laws do not apply at the micro scale. For example the laws of thermodynamics are, in Deleuze and Guattari’s phrasing³, *molar* having to do with emergent properties of large masses of objects, while particle laws are

²This sense of natural play is somewhat reminiscent of Huizinga’s cosmology of play.

³(Deleuze et al. 2009, *passim*)

molecular, having to do with much smaller collections, down to the individual. In this sense then the rules of physics are “loose,” although mathematically concrete. Put another way, physical laws are not and cannot be totalizing, because no mathematical structure could capture laws for both micro and macro level phenomena at once. While we symbolize these phenomena through the language of empirical-statistical mathematics, we do not thereby capture the real, total behavior of our object of study.

Mechanical play happens in the boundaries between these laws, in the space in which behavior cannot be pinned down. As a metaphor, consider the movement of beer in a closed up bottle. As the container shifts around, dynamic whorls and pools of liquid form, bubbles foam and pop. But at any given time the liquid remains within the container, constrained by its own particular medium and the resistance of the glass. It is in fact the container which gives it shape. And no amount of wiggling will change the properties of the liquid. This is why I consider this sort of play *mechanical*. We will later consider transformative play, which, extending our physical metaphor, could be considered chemical.

Hans, however, takes this notion of mechanical play and forms it as the basis of his argument. Throughout the book, this single notion of play is at play. It is hard to square this with his conception of play as mimesis. Surely for humans this is at least plausible – a copy with difference at the heart of the social play which then becomes transformative through that very difference – but at a physical-mechanical level it is hard to justify. Personifying physical matter, Hans might be compelled to say that particles themselves are imitating one another, though imperfectly, and that it is this imperfect copying which gives rise to playful activity. But this is not the sort of play which happens on an atomic level: there is no replication-with-difference. If we are able to place this idea onto any scientific field it might well be evolutionary biology. Repetition-with-difference is at the very heart of the biological process; it is what makes evolution what it is. But at this point the biological and physical playstyles must be made distinct. For physical playstyles we retain the phrase mechanical play, while for biological playstyles we will use the phrase *transformative play*.

At this point one has to wonder whether this account of play will hinge on a deterministic or nondeterministic reading of quantum mechanics. Such a hinge may well have a large deductive outcome for our argument, especially if we are to follow through on our reading of mechanical play, as it is clear that biological phenomena (the realm of transformative play) will necessarily supervene on physical phenomena (the realm of mechanical play). To acquiesce to determinism will lead us down the road of chaos theory. To allow for random chance will give us a base-level statistical analysis of the phenomena. Yet in either case, the outcome is the same: there is *apparent* randomness in the behavior of thermodynamic particles; there is *apparent* chaos in the movement of fluids. Whatever the underlying mechanics of the universe are – whether set by immutable, hard laws, or statistical laws of ever-diminishing proportions – the observable outcome is the same. Our goal is to discuss the *epistemological* role of play, so, for our purposes, that is enough.

Hans' understanding of theoretic play is based on the Husserlian notion of horizon. He refutes Derrida's collapse of the ontological into the epistemological, offering instead a nuanced, layered approach.

[T]he epistemological is always that which we understand of the ontological, so at any given moment it may appear as though the ontological and the epistemological are the same. But in fact their horizons are never quite the same, for the epistemological is also always structured, at least implicitly, in terms of that which it does not encompass, in terms of that which does not make 'sense' according to its own understanding. And that which does not make sense or has not yet been understood points to the larger horizon of the ontological.

— (Hans 1981, p21)

So, our epistemological understandings are limited at their horizon by the ontological. By way of example, consider a formal mathematical system. No sufficiently complex formal system can be complete, in the sense offered by Gödel's theorems. They have holes where no proof can provide an answer. However, that is not to say that there is no truth of the matter: true but unprovable statements exist, as do undecidable questions. We often turn to a different formal system – a metalanguage – in order to move past the limitations of the base-level language. But this repeats ad infinitum. At the limit of the recursion we broach what Hans would term the ontological: the purely conceptual stratum of ideal objects which no single formal system (epistemology) can broach.

There is no single ontology, no single epistemology. How to choose to orient ourselves, that is, which epistemology we take up, in part determines the objects of our world.

To begin to think of man as a purely physical, psycho-chemical creature provides new possibilities for ontological grafts, just as thinking of man as a purely linguistic creature would. And any basic change in our conception of social structure could easily enough lead to redistributions of populations, resources, and systems in ways which could profoundly affect the ontological system.

— (Hans 1981, p21-22)

The objects of our ontology vary based on the epistemology we presuppose. How we choose to frame our view of the world – the rules of the game, the hues of our attitudes – effects what objects we can discern.

But the objects within our world themselves circle down to affect our epistemology. "Play itself is the field within which the ontological framework comes to be better understood; and it is that better understanding [...] that makes grafts onto the ontological possible." (Hans 1981, p22) Play makes a change in epistemological standpoint possible, which itself allows the ontology to change, which loops back down and feeds into the epistemological. Play, Hans says, is dialectical.

He argues that the changes which play can affect are gradual, though his reasoning (AT LEAST IN CHAPTER 1) is unclear on this point.⁴

Noë claims the aesthetic attitude is *fragile*. He lists two components of aesthetic fragility which I will term *non-compellingness* and *incompleteness*. I focus here on incompleteness. As in the mathematical examples given above, no aesthetic experience is total. When viewing a mug, for example, we see its front, and know on its internal horizon that it has a back and sides. Any articulation of an aesthetic object must then be incomplete. “When we talk, for example, we always run the risk of being misunderstood, and so we need to stand ready, always, to rephrase, reformulate, rearticulate.” And this fragility is an essential aspect of the structure of our aesthetic phenomena in general. “A language that admitted no communication breakdown within language would be like a visual perception in which everything was visible from all points of view at once. These would be language or perception missing the essential aspect of fragility, and these would be unrecognizable as language or perception in the sense that we know” (Noë 2023, p174).

Simultaneously, for the very reason of its non-totality, aesthetic experiences are non-compelling, caught between the subjective and objective standpoints. Our aesthetic experiences are situated on the horizon *between* the objective and subjective. It is so to speak a step behind, a bracketing of the particular structures in which we so naturally find ourselves engaged, a birds-eye view of the structure of our rationality. As Hans puts it, object and subject emerge out of the aesthetic attitude as the epistemological subject and its corresponding ontological object. The aesthetic attitude itself underpins this very split: it is a phenomenological standpoint by which we first come to terms with the rules of play which define for us what objects there are and what methods we have for learning about them.

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C. Thi Nguyen argues in *Games: Agency as Art* that games are the artform of agency. His conception of play is similar to Hans’ conception of agentic play. Nguyen’s project is to defend a notion of aesthetic striving play. Striving play is a form of *game* play, i.e., play defined by rule-bound restrictions, in which one fully immerses oneself in the ends of the game, often for a higher-level purpose. For example, one may play a game of chess to teach their daughter, or a round of *Everything is Crab* to get some whimsy after a stressful day at work. Yet we do not pursue the ends of the game for their own sake: they are what Nguyen calls “disposable ends.” These are ends which we take up with full force as an attempt to reach some extrinsic goal, whether that be relaxation, education, exercise, or an attempt at experiencing beauty. It is this last form of striving play that Nguyen focuses on and terms *aesthetic striving play*.

While I appreciate Nguyen’s tight focus on game play, in this essay I want to broaden the horizons of what play can do.

⁴TODO: revise this section <https://pi.dev/session/#c462993f97a7b922d30c76dd154a7638> – later chapter on the aesthetic and Einstein makes this clear

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